

ANI

THE TWO SIDES
(Far left) Union home minister Amit Shah at a Meitei relief camp in Imphal, May 31; Congress leader Rahul Gandhi meets a distraught family in Moirang, Bishnupur, June 30

THE CENTRAL GOVT IS ALLEGED TO BE SOFT ON KUKI MILITANT GROUPS AS THEY REPORTEDLY HELPED EXTENDED BJP CANDIDATES WIN THE 2017 AND 2022 ASSEMBLY POLLS

ploy to grab tribal land and natural resources. Biren, though, dismisses suggestions of discrimination, claiming that more Meitei (143) families have been evicted than Kuki ones (59).

In his second term, though the BJP won a clear majority with 32 seats in 2022, Biren's tenure has been marred by challenges from within his party. Even before the ethnic clash, nearly a dozen MLAs camped in Delhi demanding his removal as CM. Because of his drive against poppy cultivation and illegal settlement in forests, Kuki MLAs, including from the BJP, have gone against him. Biren as well as his detractors are alleged to be using the Kuki-Meitei tensions to pursue their respective political objectives. By opposing poppy cultivation and illegal forest encroachment, Biren has positioned himself as the most vocal Meitei leader. The dissidents have been telling the BJP high command that Biren's mishandling of Kuki sentiments has precipitated the current crisis.

Political motives, in fact, have been ascribed even to the July 19 release of the video that went viral, a day before the monsoon session of Parliament, even though the actual incident where two women were stripped and dragged to a paddy field by armed men took place on May 4. Off the record, Kuki sources confirm that someone from the Meitei side made the video available to them. "Obviously, some people want the state to continue burning," says Biren. "There had been no incidents for eight days and suddenly the video emerges just before Parliament session."

Around three weeks earlier, on June 30, Biren had turned the tables on his dissidents by making a show of resigning as chief minister—before quickly changing his mind by citing the massive gathering of Meiteis in Imphal in support. The CM has managed to cleverly paint himself as the voice of the politically-dominant Meiteis. Hence the Modi government's dilemma—sacking him will mean the BJP being perceived as anti-Meitei, something that will be politically disastrous.

BLUNDER 3: THE IMMIGRANT BOGEY

Manipur shares a 400-km border with Myanmar, much of which is porous as only 10 per cent is fenced. A free movement regime is in place that allows residents within a 16-km range on either side to travel across for three days. This has spurred talk of a surge in unregistered settlers--a refugee influx after the 2021 coup in Myanmar only adding to it. Several Meitei organisations allege this has led to land-grabbing in the foothills surrounding the Meitei-dominated valley, the current theatre of clashes. In March, several Meitei students' organisations protested outside Biren's home, alleging that "illegal immigrants from Myanmar, Nepal and Bangladesh" were marginalising "the indigenous people of Manipur". Their contention was that this had triggered unnatural population growth in the hills. For evidence, they cite the sharp difference in decadal growth rate of population in the valley and the hills in the 2011 Census—16 per cent and 40 per cent, respectively.

As this nativist politics strengthened, the Meiteis took to routinely labelling the Kukis as "foreigners", suggesting they are migrants from Myanmar and not native to the Manipur hills, which the latter strongly dispute. The Kuki-Chin-Zomi-Mizo peoples, a web of kindred communities spread across Manipur, Mizoram and contiguous areas in Myanmar, have been caught in anti-junta armed conflict across the border. But the spillover, of refugees as also of bands of suspected combatants, has run smack into a vocabulary of fear and hate on this side. In Manipur, Biren formed a cabinet sub-committee headed by the Kuki tribal affairs minister Letpao Haokip, to identify illegal immigrants in March and later set up a Population Commission. While a report by the police last year